

Word family: ****alive / living / lively / live****

****Base word:**** alive

****Related forms / close contrasts:**** living, lively, live

****Part of speech:**** adjective (形容詞)

Your sentence:

> “That may sound a bit random, but when he speaks, everything comes ****alive****.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, ****alive**** does ****not**** literally mean “not dead.”

In ****come alive****, it means to become ****vivid, energetic, interesting, expressive, or full of apparent life****.

The speaker means that when Mr. Wong talks about ordinary things, they stop feeling flat or dull and begin to feel vivid and engaging.

****繁體中文： ****由原本平淡、靜止或缺乏吸引力的狀態，變得生動、鮮明、有活力，令人感覺彷彿有生命一樣******

****中文翻譯： ****

> “...when he speaks, everything comes ****alive****.”

「.....但當他說話的時候，一切都****變得生動鮮活起來****。」

Here:

****come alive = 變得生動、鮮活、有活力或充滿吸引力****

1. ****alive = living / not dead (生物) — 活着的；有生命的****

This is the basic literal meaning.

****Meaning:**** Still living; not dead.

Practice 1

> “The doctors were surprised that he was still ****alive****.”

「醫生很驚訝他仍然****活着****。」

Practice 2

> “Very few plants remained **alive** after the extreme cold.”

「極端寒冷過後，只有很少植物仍然**存活**。」

alive = 仍然具有生命、沒有死亡的

This meaning normally applies to:

- * people
- * animals
- * plants
- * other living organisms

2. **alive** = existing / continuing to exist (傳統 / 思想 / 事物) — 仍然存在；仍然保存着

Alive can figuratively mean that something continues to exist or has not disappeared.

Practice 3

> “The festival helps keep the old tradition **alive**.”

「這個節日有助把古老傳統**延續下去 / 保存下來**。」

Practice 4

> “Her work kept interest in the subject **alive**.”

「她的工作令大家對這個主題的興趣**繼續存在**。」

alive = 某個傳統、思想、記憶、希望或興趣仍然存在，沒有消失

Common:

- * keep a tradition alive
- * keep hope alive
- * keep a memory alive
- * keep interest alive

These share one broader **continued existence** sense.

3. **alive** = lively / active / full of activity (地方 / 環境) — 充滿活力；熱鬧

A place or environment can be **alive** when it is full of activity, movement, energy, or excitement.

Practice 5

> “The streets are **alive** with music at night.”

「晚上街道上充滿音樂，顯得非常熱鬧有活力。」

Practice 6

> “The market was **alive** with people and colour.”

「市場裡人來人往、色彩豐富，整個地方充滿生氣。」

alive = 某個地方因為充滿人物、活動、聲音或能量而顯得非常有生氣

A very common construction is:

> **alive** with + activity/sound/people/etc.

4. **alive** = vivid / expressive / engaging (故事 / 作品 / 人物描寫) — 生動的；鮮活的

This is the meaning closest to your passage.

Meaning: So vivid, expressive, or engaging that something seems to have life or energy.

Practice 7 — Original

> “When he speaks, everything comes **alive**.”

「當他說話時，一切都變得生動鮮活起來。」

Practice 8

> “The writer makes the characters feel completely **alive**.”

「這位作家把人物寫得非常鮮活生動。」

Practice 9

> “Her description made the old neighbourhood come **alive**.”

「她的描述令舊社區的景象變得**栩栩如生**。」

****alive** = 描寫、故事、人物或事物呈現得非常生動、鮮明而有生命力

This is figurative and genuinely different from literal biological life.

5. ****alive** = aware/sensitive to something (意識 / 警覺) — 察覺到 ; 對.....保持警覺

A person can be ****alive to**** a danger, possibility, issue, or opportunity.

Practice 10

> “We need to be ****alive to**** the risks involved.”

「我們需要對當中的風險保持**警覺 / 有所察覺**。」

Practice 11

> “Good teachers are ****alive to**** changes in their students’ behaviour.”

「好的老師會對學生行為上的變化保持**敏感和留意**。」

****be alive to something** = 清楚察覺某件事的重要性、可能性或危險，並保持注意

This is a distinct, somewhat formal use.

6. ****alive** = active/operating electrically or technically (電力 / 系統) — 帶電的 ; 仍在運作的

In technical contexts, ****alive**** can mean electrically live or still active.

Practice 12

> “Be careful—the wire is still ****alive****.”

「小心，那條電線仍然**帶電**。」

Practice 13

> “The circuit remains ****alive**** even after the main switch is turned off.”

「即使主開關已關閉，電路仍可能**帶電 / 仍然通電**。」

****alive = 電線、電路或系統仍然有電流、能量或處於活動狀態****

This is an established modern technical meaning and clearly distinct from ordinary biological life.

Fixed expression: ****come alive — 變得生動 / 有活力****

This is the exact construction in your passage.

Practice 14 — Original

> “When he speaks, everything ****comes alive****.”

「當他說話時，一切都****變得生動鮮活起來****。」

Practice 15

> “The city really ****comes alive**** after dark.”

「入夜後，這座城市才真正****熱鬧起來 / 充滿活力****。」

****come alive = 由較平淡、靜止或沒有生氣的狀態，變得生動、活躍、有吸引力****

This is best treated as a fixed construction built from the figurative meanings of ****alive****, rather than another unrelated sense.

Fixed expression: ****keep something alive — 使……繼續存在****

Practice 16

> “The museum helps keep local history ****alive****.”

「博物館有助把本地歷史和文化****保存並延續下去****。」

Practice 17

> “They are trying to keep the language ****alive****.”

「他們正努力讓這種語言****繼續流傳 / 保持生命力****。」

****keep something alive = 防止某個傳統、思想、語言、記憶或希望消失****

This belongs to Meaning 2.

Important distinction: **alive** vs **living**

These overlap, but their grammar differs importantly.

alive

normally comes **after a linking verb**:

> “The fish is **alive**.” 

Normally not:

> “an **alive** fish” 

living

can come before a noun:

> “a **living** fish” 

It can also mean “currently alive”:

> “one of the greatest **living** writers”

= 當今仍在世的偉大作家之一

So:

alive = 通常作表語，表示仍然活着

living = 可直接修飾名詞，也可表示活着的 / 現存的

Important distinction: **alive** vs **lively**

This is especially important.

alive

can literally mean:

> not dead

or figuratively:

> vivid / full of life

****lively****

means:

> energetic, active, cheerful, or full of movement

> “a lively child”

= 活潑的小孩

But:

> “The child is alive.”

= 那個孩子仍然活着。

These are completely different meanings.

So:

****alive ≠ lively****

Important distinction: ****alive vs live****

****alive****

adjective:

> “The animal is alive.”

= 動物仍然活着。

****live****

can be an adjective meaning happening in real time:

> “a live broadcast”

= 現場直播

or a verb:

> “I live in Hong Kong.”

= 我住在香港。

Because **live** already carries substantial independent polysemy, it should be treated as a separate target rather than expanded fully inside **alive**.

Important distinction: **alive** vs **awake**

alive

= living / not dead

awake

= not sleeping

A person can be:

> alive but asleep

So:

alive = 生死狀態

awake = 睡眠狀態

They are not interchangeable.

Important distinction: **alive** vs **active**

alive

can mean full of life or still existing.

active

means doing things, functioning, participating, or producing effects.

For example:

> “The tradition is still alive.”

= 傳統仍然存在。

> “The organization is still active.”

= 組織仍然在運作 / 活動。

The ideas overlap in figurative contexts, but they are not identical.

Related lexical note

Unlike many adjectives, ****alive**** does not have a large productive derivational family.

The most useful learning value lies in its contrasts and constructions:

* alive

* alive with

* alive to

* come alive

* keep something alive

The Golden Manual says that when a family is genuinely small, it should remain small instead of being artificially expanded.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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alive — living/not dead	人、動物、植物等仍然具有生命，沒有死亡
alive — continuing to exist	傳統、記憶、希望、興趣等仍然存在，沒有消失
alive — full of activity	地方或環境因充滿人物、聲音、活動或能量而顯得非常有生氣
alive — vivid/expressive	故事、人物、描寫或事物呈現得非常生動、鮮明而有生命力
alive to something	清楚察覺某件事的重要性、可能性或危險，並保持注意
alive — electrical/technical	電線、電路或設備仍然帶電、通電或保持活動狀態
come alive	由平淡、靜止或缺乏生氣的狀態變得生動、活躍或有吸引力
keep something alive	令傳統、思想、語言、記憶、希望等繼續存在而不消失

For your original sentence

> "...when he speaks, everything comes **alive**."

The exact meaning is:

alive = 生動、鮮活、有生命力和吸引力的狀態

More specifically:

come alive = 由原本普通或平淡的狀態，變得非常生動、鮮明、有活力

So:

> **everything comes alive**

= **一切都變得生動鮮活起來**

For your database, I would count **6 genuinely useful core meanings** for **alive**:

1. **living / not dead**
2. **continuing to exist**
3. **full of activity or energy**
4. **vivid / expressive / seemingly full of life**
5. **alive to something — aware and alert to it**
6. **technical — electrically live / active**

I would treat **come alive**, **keep something alive**, and **alive with** as important constructions under these senses rather than inflate the core count.